

Reading, Then Rewriting, the Cosmic Text: Kāshifī's *Jewels of Exegesis* and the Timurid Canonization of Tafsir as Magic

Matthew Melvin-Koushki
University of South Carolina

Like some immeasurable kabbalistic structure, all of reality is really made of letters, words, thoughts, in short, of a writing mind, but we only catch glimmers of this Logos, this Meaning of all meaning. As a result, we are not the writers but the written.¹

پس اینجا اول آمد عین آخر
نباشد نیز باطن غیر ظاهر²

In the annals of Islamic occultism, esoteric interpretations of quranic suras, verses, words and letters naturally abound. They became the basis of lettrism (*‘ilm al-ḥurūf*) in particular, coeval twin to Hebrew kabbalah, which pivots on the mystery of the *muqatta‘āt* to approach scripture and cosmos alike as a deconstructable and magically reconstructable text. An important driver of imperial ideology and scientific modernity, this occult, Pythagorean science enjoyed hegemony and ubiquity throughout the post-Mongol and especially Persianate world until the colonial period; its vogue persists in elite clerical and non-elite internet circles to the present. During its early modern heyday, lettrist interpretations came to permeate many Arabic and Persian genres as a matter of course, from chronicles and riddles to poetry and treatises on various occult sciences, and of course Quran exegesis itself.³ But it would appear that only one fully lettrist *tafsīr* was ever penned: the Persian *Jewels of Exegesis* (*Javāhir al-tafsīr*) of Ḥusayn Vā‘iz Kāshifī, who died in 1505 on the eve of the Safavid takeover of Herat.

This famed Timurid polymath, Herati preacher and Naqshbandī Sufi produced an everyman's library encompassing the full range of Islamicate learning, and his elegant Persian reformulations and syntheses of Arabic classics have enjoyed wide popularity down to the modern period. These include his *Lights of Canopus* (*Anvār-i Suhaylī*), a retelling of the *Kalīla wa-Dimna* animal fables; *Garden of the Martyrs* (*Rawzat al-shuhadā*), an ‘Alid martyrology still in constant use; *Ethics for Muḥsin* (*Akhlāq-i Muḥsinī*), on ethics and statecraft; and *Sublime Gifts* or *Gifts for*

¹ Kripal, *Better horrors* 332.

² Kāshifī, *Javāhir al-tafsīr* 373; the line is translated in the Conclusion below.

³ On the philosophical, scientific, aesthetic, technological, political and indeed military salience of lettrism see e.g. Melvin-Koushki, *The New Brethren*; idem, *Is (Islamic) occult science science?*

‘*Alī* (*Mavāhib-i ‘Alīyya*), a literary and Sufi tafsir. He was likewise heavily invested in various occult sciences, especially lettrism and astrology, and his grimoire *Qasimian Secrets* (*Asrār-i Qāsimī*) was expanded into a who’s who of Safavid state occultism.⁴

The *Jewels of Exegesis*, written between 1485-87, was left incomplete, ending with the first 84 verses of *Sūrat al-Nisā’*. Yet its two volumes epitomize Kāshifi’s synthesizing, encyclopedic, ornate and occultist approach throughout his career. It effectively constructs a canon of Quran exegesis that is explicitly lettrist in a way no tafsir had been before, fusing such major Sufi authorities as al-Qushayrī, Ibn al-‘Arabī and al-Būnī, on the one hand, and philosophers like Ibn Sīnā, Fakhr al-Dīn Rāzī and Ibn Turka, on the other, into a single exegetical tradition. And that tradition is very much Sunni, although deeply imamophile. It is also very much Timurid and Naqshbandi, reflecting the author’s personal Sufi commitments and relationships at court by drawing on such celebrated shaykhs as Muḥammad Pārsā, ‘Ubayd Allāh Aḥrār and ‘Abd al-Raḥmān Jāmī (his brother-in-law), as well as ‘Abd Allāh Anṣārī, patron saint of Timurid Herat.⁵ As such, it represents a mainstream counterpoint to the anarchic stylings of the Ḥurūfiyya, whose Persian lettrist exegeses, wildly creative, remained strictly fringe.⁶ Yet Islamicists have tended to assume such marginal movements to be more representative of “Islamic esotericism,” neglecting mainstream scholarly manifestations as a consequence, or simply disappearing everything into the catchall category of “mysticism.” By contrast, Kāshifi’s tafsirs, while indeed often Sufi in tenor, were designed and received as mainstream summas of the science.

As remedy, this article brings the *Javāhir al-tafsīr* to modern scholarly attention as a key node for understanding the early modern evolution of Quran exegesis, esoteric or otherwise. It likewise represents a watershed in the canonization of lettrism as Persianate imperial science.⁷ Still mostly unstudied and only half edited, Kāshifi’s masterwork more than deserves full study as a convenient one-stop shop for the best of the exegetical and the lettrist arts alike at the turn of the sixteenth century. As the eminent Twelver biographer Muḥammad-Bāqir Kh^wānsārī (d. 1895) declared in encomium:

The array of benefits comprised by its introductory discussions are so vast as to be virtually unmatched by any other work in the genre, the objectives it harbors so sublime, its hadiths and bons mots so rare and fine as to seduce the hearts of all who have eyes!⁸

⁴ This astrology-lettrism fusion is the hallmark of Timurid techno-imperialism from Ibn Turka onward. On the man and his Persian encyclopedic project see Subtelny, Kāshifi’s *Asrār-i qāsimī*; idem, A man of letters; idem, Husayn Va‘iz-i Kashifi.

⁵ On Kāshifi’s late Timurid context see e.g. Gross and Urunbaev, *The letters*; Manz, *Power, politics and religion*; Subtelny, *Timurids in transition*. Notably, despite his close and indeed familial connection to Jāmī, here he simply ignores the latter’s animus toward Ibn Turka and his circle and his denunciation of their lettrist philosophy, which is canonized in the *Javāhir*; see Melvin-Koushki, *The quest*, 423-7.

⁶ On this movement see Bashir, *Fazlallah Astarabadi*; Mir-Kasimov, *Words of power*.

⁷ Melvin-Koushki, *Islamicate empire*.

⁸ *Rawḍāt al-jannāt* iii, 230. The same source reports Kāshifi’s preternatural ability to silence naysayers on the spot, in a particularly memorable and telling case using numerological means (*ibid.* iii, 229-30).

Constructing the Exegetical-cum-Lettrist Canon

The *Javāhir* has been the subject of only two preliminary studies to date: by its editor, Javād ‘Abbāsī (2000), who provides historical contextualization and textual analysis; and by Kristin Zahra Sands (2003), who briefly compares it with Kāshifī’s second and complete Persian tafsir, *Mavāhib-i ‘Alīyya*, aka *Tafsir-i Husaynī*, both dedicated to the Timurid commander and patron of the arts Mīr ‘Alī-Shīr Navā‘ī (d. 1501) during the latter years of the Timurid Renaissance.⁹ Simply put, the *Mavāhib* became one of the most popular tafsirs ever written—it survives in hundreds of manuscripts, as well as in many lithographs and modern printings—due to its streamlined, accessible, entertaining, poetical and engaging style and focus on Sufi sources and stories. The incomplete *Javāhir* achieved less fame (though it does survive in at least 75 manuscripts and three abridged versions), being much more technical, sophisticated and scholarly, though also gorgeous and prosimetric. Yet it was clearly conceived by the author as the *Mavāhib*’s necessary theoretical framework, which it develops in exhaustive detail.¹⁰ Indeed, the latter was commissioned by Navā‘ī as a summary version (*mukhtaṣar*) of the same. Thus even the *Mavāhib* concludes on an overtly lettrist note with a meditation on the cosmic, psychological and physiological significance of the number five in Sūrat al-Nās, for a full account of which the reader is referred to the *Javāhir*, followed by a brief explanation as to why the Quran begins with *B* and ends with *S*.¹¹ That his contemporaries received them as a pair is suggested by the eminent Timurid-Safavid historian Khwāndamīr (d. ca. 1536): the *Javāhir* and the *Mavāhib* are the first two works listed in his entry on Kāshifī.¹² This impression is corroborated by the 1536 produc-

⁹ *Javāhir al-tafsīr* 21-116 (introduction); Sands, On the popularity. See also the brief account in Ayāzī, *Javāhir al-tafsīr*. A later recension accordingly titles it *Jewels of Exegesis: A Boon for the Commander* (*Javāhir al-tafsīr li-tuḥfat al-amīr*), i.e., Mīr ‘Alī-Shīr Navā‘ī, but the author himself refers to it elsewhere as *Jewels in Exegesis of the Almighty’s Speech* (*Javāhir al-tafsīr li-kalām al-qadīr*), with its two volumes being named *Tafsīr-i ‘arūs* and *Tafsīr-i zahrāvayn* respectively (*Javāhir*, 59). Kāshifī also penned a short *‘irfānī* commentary on Sūrat Yūsuf.

¹⁰ That is, the *Mavāhib* consistently glosses over the more occult matters to which the *Javāhir* is wholly devoted. Thus, for example, the former investigates the *basmala* not at all, whereas at least a quarter of the latter dwells on its secrets and their practical applications. Similarly, the former opens its commentary on Sūrat al-Baqara by asserting that the *muqatta‘āt* comprise the secrets of the Quran known only to the elite, then merely cites a popular interpretation of *ALM* (Kāshifī, *Mavāhib-i ‘Alīyya* i, 3).

¹¹ Ibid. iii, 454-5:

That the divine Speech opens with the letter *B* and closes with the letter *S* is a mighty secret: for together they can make [the word] *bas*. As Arabs say, “That’s enough for you!” (*bas-ak*), meaning “That suffices you!” (*ḥasb-ak*). So too can [we read *BS* to mean] “What We’ve given you between the two Sanctuaries will suffice you from the two Worlds!” And weirdly enough, these two letters happen to mean precisely the same in Persian [as they do in Arabic], that is, “all well and good.” So sings the sage Sanā‘ī on this theme:

Why does the Quran start and end with *B* and *S*?

Because on religion’s path it suffices (*bas*) as your guide.

The Torah similarly opens with *B* but closes with *L*—a letter pair likewise the site of much kabbalist meditation and speculation over the last millennium.

¹² *Tārīkh-i Ḥabīb al-siyar* iv, 345-6. Kāshifī’s preaching style was equally gorgeous (ibid.):

tion of a gorgeous Safavid courtly copy of the *Mavāhib* under the title of the *Javāhir*.¹³ Going forward, these twin tafsirs must be studied in tandem to understand the theory behind Kāshifī's extremely successful exegetical practice.

But the *Javāhir* comprises both lettrist theory and lettrist practice in its own right. In particular, as overarching framework, it combines the metaphysics of Ibn 'Arabī and the talismanry of Būnī in order to prove the status of tafsir as a supreme, comprehensive and universally useful and necessary science—especially medically. The *Javāhir* is unique in its genre on three counts:

- 1) It is both gnostic (*'irfānī*) and traditionist in its approach;
- 2) Its impeccable prosimetric style is rivaled only by the *Unveiling Secrets* (*Kashf al-asrār*) of Rashīd al-Dīn Maybudī (d. 1165), a similarly gnostic tafsir, but not lettrist, reflecting a cultural seachange in the intervening three and a half centuries;
- 3) It is the most thoroughgoingly lettrist tafsir currently known, at least in formal generic terms.¹⁴

The *Javāhir* is also unique in the number and variety of the authorities it cites. Unusually, and helpfully for the modern researcher, titles and/or authors are consistently given by name. Its pattern of citation aims for ecumenical comprehensiveness, giving equal space to authorities medieval and modern, non-Sufi and Sufi, Timurid and Ottoman, Sunni and Shi'i. Individual sections combine Qushayrī, Ghazālī and Ibn Waḥshiyya with Junayd, Jurjānī and Fakhr-i Rāzī, or Sulamī, Zamakhsharī and Sakkākī with Rūmī, Qūnavī and Imam 'Alī, or Anṣārī, Ibn Barraḡān and Rāghib Iṣfahānī with Ḥakīm Tirmidhī, Sa'd al-Dīn Ḥamūya and Ibn Turka. Kāshifī's Ottoman near-contemporary Shams al-Dīn Fanārī (d. 1431), a committed Akbarian, is the first exegete cited and often invoked throughout. But pride of place goes to Ibn 'Arabī and Būnī themselves, as noted, whose lettrist theory and lettrist practice serve as backbone to Kāshifī's exegetical canon as a whole.

Its structure similarly combines traditionalism with innovation, following the author's general procedure throughout his oeuvre.¹⁵ After first laying out the discipline of tafsir and its supremacy among sciences, Kāshifī proceeds to summarize the arguments for the Quran's supremacy among revealed scriptures, as well as its various names. On the theological debate over its preexistence or origination in time, he summarizes the Mu'tazilī, Ḥanbalī and Karrāmī

In astrology (*'ilm-i nujūm*) and belles-lettres (*inshā*) he was without peer in his era, and peer to all in his mastery of the rest of the sciences. He would preach in the loveliest tones and with the most enchanting voice, employing the most alluring expressions and the most beautiful allusions in explication of the meaning of the clear verses of the divine Speech and the occult secrets (*ghavāmiz-i asrār*) of the Sayings of the holy Messenger.

¹³ Copied by one Naṣr Allāh b. Sayyid Aḥmad al-Ḥāfiẓ al-Tabrīzī, it is preserved as Dublin, Chester Beatty Library, MS Per. 204.

¹⁴ Famously, Ibn 'Arabī conceived of his oceanic *Meccan Openings* (and indeed oeuvre as a whole) as a total tafsir of the Two Books, to which lettrism is the cosmic key—a primary model for Kāshifī's exegetical approach. See Gril, *The science*; and below.

¹⁵ Such a combination—contradictory to the modern constitution—makes it a distinctively early modern work; see Melvin-Koushki, *Tahqīq* vs. *taqlīd*.

positions, concluding with the Ash‘arī counterargument. He proceeds to prove the Quran’s all-comprehensiveness by detailing the sciences derived directly therefrom, whether philosophical (*ḥikmī*), literary (*adabī*) or legal (*shar‘ī*), as well as the sciences associated therewith: calligraphy, phonetics, cantillation, verse and sura numbering, distinguishing similar verses, verse stops and readings. Then the external sciences necessary for tafsir—linguistics, history and genealogy, stylistics and rhetoric, theology, jurisprudence, hadith—and its internal concerns, from occasions of revelation, parallelism and “weird words” (*gharīb al-Qur‘ān*) to sermoncraft, ethics and proofs of inimitability, followed by exegetes’ terms of art and further theoretical and terminological considerations. (His discussion of the letter and the dot, translated below, is especially lettrist.) He then redoubles his defense of quranic inimitability (*i‘jāz*) according to seven main, often occult proofs: its sheer elegance in both word selection and syntax; its wondrous and weird (*‘ajīb u gharīb*) style; its reports of the past; its reports of the future; its overwhelming effect on reciter and audience alike; its perpetual freshness despite repeated recitation; the various types of sciences and knowledge it comprises. These standard disciplinary ground rules established at length, Kāshifī adds an equally long section on the supplicatory—which is to say, magical—uses of the Quran (*isti‘āza*); together both sections run over 200 pages in the edition. Only then does he begin the tafsir proper, treating each word of the Fātiḥa, and especially its opening *basmala*, in exhaustive, often lettrist detail over the remaining 531 pages of the first volume.

More specifically, Kāshifī glorifies the science of quranic exegesis by means of several classificatory schemes. In the first place, it combines transmission (*rivāyat*), achieved through study (*dirāsāt*); comprehension (*dirāyat*), achieved through discernment (*firāsāt*, aka clairvoyance); and direct inheritance (*virāsāt*), achieved through sacral power (*valāyat*). While differing sharply as methods for ascertaining the divine intention and involving seemingly incompatible modes of human experience, all converge on the same truth. Similarly, it is among the noblest of all sciences given its exalted objective, which it achieves through the combination of comprehensiveness and usefulness, in contrast with lesser sciences. Unlike the metaphysical sciences (*‘ulūm-i ilāhiyya*), which are but means to knowledge of the divine, this science constitutes that knowledge itself.

As such, tafsir is both supremely noble in its object and of universal utility in four respects. It is categorically superior to other sciences, like medicine (*ṭibb*) is superior to veterinary medicine (*bayṭara*), since human bodies are superior to animal bodies in the order of being. It is more universally useful than other sciences, like writing (*kitābat*) is to surveying (*masāḥat*), which is of much more limited scope. It has the surest epistemological foundation, like arithmetic (*ḥisāb*), whose proofs constitute certain knowledge, in contrast with astrology (*aḥkām-i nujūm*), which is speculative and conjectural. Finally, it is universally necessary, like jurisprudence (*fiqh*), without which no one can order their life aright, in contrast with medicine, which is only occasionally necessary.¹⁶

¹⁶ *Javāhir al-tafsīr* 127-312. Kāshifī’s long introduction slots neatly into the classification of sciences (*taṣnīf al-‘ulūm*) genre, and his reformulation of tafsir as a lettrist science prefigures by almost a century the Ottoman polymath and imperial judge Taṣkōprizāde’s (d. 1561) remarkable reclassification in his comprehensive encyclopedia *Key to Felicity and Lamp to Mastery* (*Miftāḥ al-sa‘āda wa-miṣbāḥ al-siyāda*) of lettrism as a major subset of the quranic sciences

Such valorizations of the tafsir genre are hardly uncommon, of course. But in Kāshifī's case, it is not mere rhetoric: the *Javāhir* actually does combine metaphysics and physics, does combine religion, science and technology, in a way not seen in the genre before, at least to my knowledge. (A huge amount of basic philological labor remains to be done.) Its introduction alone (as Kh^wānsārī notes) is especially comprehensive, providing a total framework to the reader—one that carefully distinguishes between the manifest (*ẓāhir*) and occult (*bāṭin*) aspects of the science, and between outward or literalist (*qishrī*) and inward or lettrist (*lubābī*) approaches to the same. While exoteric tafsirs are perfectly valid in their own right, esoteric ones are even more so—and the two must always be combined.

If tafsir is a supreme science, it is only so through the equally supreme—because quintessentially quranic—science that is lettrism. Kāshifī accordingly dwells on the special and active properties (*khāṣṣiyyāt*, *khavāṣṣ*) of certain verses and suras, as well as modes of consciousness-focused (*bāṭinī*) meditation on and activation of the quranic text. He emphasizes quranic prayer as a particularly effective form of magic, a tried and true technology. His reframing of the standard doctrine of quranic inimitability (*ʾiʿjāz*) is quietly revolutionary in this context. Quite simply, Kāshifī makes it into a specifically *occult* property:

The arrangement of [the Quran's] expressions is astonishing (*ʿajīb*), the immediacy of its meanings gorgeous and weird (*gharīb*)!¹⁷

Its composition is so astonishing and its style so weird as to be totally incomparable to the stylistics of the Arabs.¹⁸

Again, this may seem like mere time-honored rhetoric; but the context, and Kāshifī's status as an important author on the occult sciences, aka the sciences of the weird (*ʿulūm-i gharība*), leaves no doubt: he is using *gharīb* here in a simultaneously poetical and technical sense. The Quran is very much a *paranormal* text—hence its inimitability is a property subject to *scientific proof*.¹⁹

generally and tafsir specifically; see Melvin-Koushki, Powers of One 173-6. By contrast, Kāshifī's qualification of astrology here as a conjectural (*takhmīmī*) science continues long tradition, and is no criticism—our encyclopedic author is predictably responsible for a seven-treatise astrological summa (*Sabʿa-yi Kāshifiyya*) too, whose surviving, final treatise on elections, *Lunar Proofs* (*Lavāyih al-qamar*), was similarly a bestseller; see Tourkin and Vesel, The contribution.

¹⁷ *Javāhir al-tafsīr* 140.

¹⁸ Ibid. 251.

¹⁹ In early modern Persianate usage, and in Persian to this day, by far the most common descriptor for the occult sciences is in fact not *khafī*, occult, but rather *gharīb*, weird and wondrous. That is, the occult sciences—technically difficult and hence rarely mastered (another sense of *gharīb*)—are a distinct subset of the natural, mathematical and religious disciplines that induce wonder (*taʿajjub*) by empirically investigating and technologically harnessing the weird. To put it into more technical modern English parlance, they are the sciences of the paranormal, currently relegated to the still marginal academic field of parapsychology. For Kāshifī, by contrast, Islam simply is magic, and the occult is by definition wondrous and weird—hence a ubiquitous ethical, political, aesthetic, scientific and technological imperative informing virtually every Islamic genre. See Melvin-Koushki, Is (Islamic) occult science science?; Zadeh, *Wonders and rarities*; Khan, *The broken spell*; Harb, *Arabic poetics* ch. 5.

As he explains, in classic Sunni-Shi'i lettrist fashion:

The seventh aspect of [quranic] inimitability is the fact that it comprises various types of sciences and knowledge (*'ulūm u ma'ārifī*) the Arabs could not have known, or even the Messenger (God bless and keep him and his House) himself before the commencement of his prophetic mission. These include the occult sciences with which God Most High infused His letters and words, the knowledge of which He has entrusted to certain of the elite at His glorious court: the Imams of the House of the Prophet (*a'imma-yi ahl-i bayt*) (peace be upon them), who possessed some of this [occult knowledge] by way of lettrist principles (*qavānīn-i jafriyya*), keys to the treasures of the mysteries of the Quran and Hadith; and certain of the greatest saints of this community, such as Shaykh Muḥyī l-Dīn Ibn al-ʿArabī, Shaykh Sa'd al-Dīn al-Ḥamūya (God sanctify their spirits) and others, who discovered another part of it by way of unveiling (*kashf*).²⁰

Concluding his discussion of the superiority of the Quran to every other revealed book, Kāshifī sets the stage for the lettrist analyses that follow by citing, as an argument-clincher, the occult properties unique to it. The fact that the Quran allows one to achieve total, experiential control over engendered existence (*taṣarrufāt-i kullī dar 'ālam-i kawn u fasād*) proves its identity with the fabric of reality:

It having thus been demonstrated with traditional and rational proofs that this Book is the noblest and greatest of all revealed scriptures, its verses clearer and superior to those of other codices, its inimitability more evident than any other prophetic miracle, the divine names it contains greater than all those given in previous scriptures, it follows that its special properties must be more beneficial and more manifold than the active properties of any other book—and indeed, by means of its special property one may achieve total control over engendered existence. The inner meaning of the hadith *The Opening of the Book is the healing of every sickness* (*fātiḥatu l-kitābi shifā' min kullī dā'*) refers plainly to this fact. The account of spells (*ruqā'*) and amulets (*ta'āwīz*) based on quranic words referenced by the holy Messenger (God bless him and keep him and his House) likewise constitutes a reliable proof in this regard.²¹

Kāshifī supports this scientific and technological argument by referring his reader to the classics on quranic and divine-names prayer: the Corpus Būnianam (*rasā'il-i Būniyya*); the *Active Properties* [of the Quran] (*Khawāṣṣ [al-Qur'ān]*) of the Jerusalemite physician Abū 'Abd Allāh Muḥammad al-Tamīmī (fl. 1000), in service to Fatimid caliphs in Cairo; and the *Strung Pearl* (*al-Durr al-naẓīm*) of 'Abd Allāh al-Yāfī'ī (d. Mecca 1367), the Yemeni Shāfi'ī scholar famed as the Shaykh al-Ḥijāz. To these names he adds the great Maghribi saint-mage Aḥmad al-Sabtī

²⁰ *Javāhir al-tafsīr* 255. In early modern Persianate usage, *jaf'r* came to be used metonymically for lettrism as a whole. On Ḥamūya in particular—with Ibn 'Arabī and Būnī a primary source for Timurid and Safavid lettrists—see Uy, *Lost in a sea of letters*.

²¹ *Javāhir al-tafsīr* 261-2.

(d. 1205) and the otherwise unknown Abū ‘Abd Allāh al-Zakzākī—as well as, bizarrely, Ibn Khaldūn (d. 1406) “the Egyptian”! Given the now-celebrated Tunisian historian’s condemnations of philosophy, natural science and Sufism generally and lettrism and other occult sciences specifically, and his failed vendetta against precisely those lettrists valorized by Kāshifī, this last citation may be plausibly read as a satirical jab, testament to the triumph of that science from the ninth Islamic century onward.²²

This canonizing project was continued by Kāshifī’s son ‘Alī Ṣafī (d. 1533), likewise a committed Naqshbandī scholar and preacher in Herat, whose two Persian lettrist works draw upon the same classics but expand this list to create a more detailed intellectual history of the science from the Ancients to the Imams and from the Imams to the Moderns. Chief among them is his *Amulet of Protection from the Trials of Time* (*Ḥirz al-amān min fitan al-zamān*); constructed on a 5-5-12 pattern in honor of the Five Folk of the Mantle and the Twelve Imams but drawing exclusively on Sunni sources, this imamophile landmark summa of applied lettrism became a Safavid bestseller. In its introduction, ‘Alī Ṣafī divides lettrists into two camps: Realists (*ahl-i ḥaqīqat*) and Activists (*ahl-i khāṣṣiyyat*), representing theory and practice respectively. The greatest authorities on the science, like Ghazālī, Būnī, Ibn ‘Arabī, Yāfī‘ī, Tamīmī and Ibn Turka, are renowned as masters of both approaches. The *Amulet of Protection* itself constitutes a comprehensive Activist manual, valorizing lettrism as a rigorously experimentalist (*tajribī*) technology of universal—and especially political—application.²³

Ever the devoted son, ‘Alī Ṣafī’s canon of lettrism culminates with Kāshifī himself, who penned no less than five works in this vein—including in the first place the *Javāhir* and the *Mavāhib* both.²⁴ While the former clearly represents a gorgeous and masterful marriage of the Realist and Activist approaches, it seems odd to class the latter as a lettrist text: its style is so accessible and popular, so Manifest, that any lettrist basis remains entirely Occult. But presumably this is precisely ‘Alī Ṣafī’s point: his father’s two tafsirs are two sides of the same occult-scientific coin, both equally crucial to any quranic exegesis worth the name.

Kāshifī and the New Brethren of Purity

‘Alī Ṣafī’s neat division of lettrism into theory and practice is not original to him, but was proposed by Ibn Turka (d. 1432) in his seminal 1414 treatise *On Letters* (*R. Ḥurūf*), associating the

²² It is likewise a testament to Kāshifī’s encyclopedic drive, bent on incorporating even obscure authors into various genre canons. That he here cites the *Muqaddima* is nevertheless remarkable, and hints at the persistence in Timurid Iran of fleeing stories of its otherwise forgotten puritan, occultophobe author; that he actually consulted a copy is suggested by the fact that he follows Ibn Khaldūn, always sloppy, in probably mistakenly associating al-Sabṭī with al-Būnī. See Gardiner, *Esotericism* 246-7; idem, *Ibn Khaldūn*; Melvin-Koushki, In defense of geomancy.

²³ On this work and its intellectual history, as well as ‘Alī Ṣafī’s and Kāshifī’s other lettrist treatises, see Melvin-Koushki, *The quest* 271-80; idem, *Qizilbash magic*.

²⁴ ‘Alī Ṣafī also composed the *Mavāhib*’s concluding chronogram—a genre whose ubiquity in Persian letters testifies to an occult sensibility, a lettrist consciousness, pervading early modern Islamic societies more generally. See Kāshifī, *Mavāhib-i ‘Alīyya*, 3:455; Melvin-Koushki, *Of Islamic grammatology*.

first with Ibn ‘Arabī and Ḥamūya and the second with Būnī.²⁵ Preeminent occult philosopher of the early Timurid Empire, Ibn Turka’s life project was the systematization of lettrism as universal, imperial and above all mathematical science, combining metaphysics and physics in equal measure. That he succeeded in that project to no little degree, albeit mostly posthumously, is reflected in his reception by Kāshifī and son, likewise in service to the Timurid state (and the latter to the Safavid one too), who were conscious beneficiaries of the Isfahani sage’s labors, as their occasional but admiring references to him testify. More significantly, however, their general citation patterns map perfectly onto those of Ibn Turka’s own scholarly network: the New Brethren of Purity.

Active between Mamluk Egypt, Timurid Iran and Ottoman Anatolia in the last decade of the fourteenth century and the first three of the fifteenth, these first New Brethren styled themselves such after the famed Ikhwān al-Ṣafā’, that confraternity of Pythagoreanizing occultists and encyclopedists of tenth-century ‘Abbasid Iraq. But the Old Brethren were not lettrists, and labored in anonymity; the New Brethren, famed imperial scholars to a man, rather held up lettrism as quintessence of Pythagorean occult science—a cosmopolitical thesis that would be gorgeously algorithmically embodied in Persianate cultures through the colonial era.²⁶ To that end, they began a canonization process that Kāshifī and ‘Alī Ṣafī would effectively complete a century later, whereby this science came to be defined by the Sufis Būnī, Ibn ‘Arabī and Ḥamūya in particular, but also modulated by preeminent philosophers like Ibn Sīnā and Fakhr-i Rāzī, to provide for a new, universal metaphysics-physics.²⁷ Thus father and son cite Ibn Turka in the company of these greats, together with Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī (d. 1397), Tabrizi lettrist-chemist-geomancer to the Mamluk sultan, pivot of the New Brethren network in Cairo and Ibn Turka’s mentor, and Sharaf al-Dīn ‘Alī Yazdī (d. 1454), celebrated Timurid historian, mathematician and lettrist, who was Ibn Turka’s mentee and best friend. Likewise Kāshifī’s frequent dependence in the *Javāhir* on Fanārī, a member of the same network as a fellow Akbarian.²⁸

With such citations, Kāshifī claims card-carrying membership in the New Brethren of Purity, and frames the *Javāhir* as a culmination of their lettristPythagorean project. Most notably,

²⁵ This work is edited and translated in Melvin-Koushki, *Persian Pythagoreanism*; Ibn Turka makes this Ibn ‘Arabī-Ḥamūya pairing explicit in the introduction to his *Investigations*. Significantly, ‘Alī Ṣafī dispenses with Ibn Turka’s overneat identification, holding up Ibn ‘Arabī and Būnī as masters of both approaches. On Ḥamūya see now Uy, *Lost in a sea*.

²⁶ On this scholarly network see e.g. Melvin-Koushki, *The New Brethren*; Fleischer, *Ancient wisdom*; Binbaş, *Intellectual networks*; Gardiner, *Occultist encyclopedism*.

²⁷ On Ibn Sīnā’s Safavid reception as Pythagorean occultist see Melvin-Koushki, *World as (Arabic) text*; on Fakhr-i Rāzī’s embrace of occultism as a primary vehicle for living philosophy see Noble, *Philosophising the occult*.

²⁸ Melvin-Koushki, *The quest* 18, 50, 54, 67. Given his heavy investment in the project of the New Brethren and awareness of Ottoman trends, it is curious that Kāshifī does not cite ‘Abd al-Raḥmān al-Biṣṭāmī (d. 1454) as well, the most prolific member of that network in Ottoman Anatolia, whose many lettrist and occultist works exhibit the same encyclopedic and canonizing objective. Yet Biṣṭāmī goes even farther than Kāshifī to this end: in his *Horizons’ Sun* (*Shams al-āfāq*) this Antiochene New Brother lists no less than 238 titles he claims to have personally consulted as basis for the lettrist canon; see Gardiner, *Occultist encyclopedism*. But political reasons likely intervened. As that may be, this Antiochene New Brother was no popularizer, in sharp contrast to Kāshifī, many of whose works enjoyed bestseller status across the vast Persianate world through the colonial era, and a few even to the present.

to further prove the inimitably all-comprehensive nature of the Quran, comprising all the knowledge of the Ancients and the Moderns, he cites these lines by Sanā'ī (d. 1131) in his *Garden of Reality* (*Ḥadīqat al-ḥaqīqa*):

Do you seek the pearls of the Separation?
Go to the sea of *He made known the Recitation*,
And find therein the pearl of certain knowledge
forged of the alchemy of religion,
From which ramifies the science of *the First and the Last*
by way of *the Occult and the Manifest!*²⁹

This quranic verse, *He is the First and the Last, the Manifest and the Occult* (Q 57:3), was the motto of the New Brethren, constantly invoked throughout their oeuvres as epitome of the union of opposites (*majma' al-aḍḍād*). The same cosmo-semiotic principle was codified in Latin as the *coincidentia oppositorum* by Kāshifī's earlier Catholic contemporary Nicholas Cusanus, the German cardinal, who died in 1464.³⁰ But nowhere does it reach a fuller philosophical, scientific, technological and political significance than in Ibn Turka's *Investigations* (*Kitāb al-Mafāḥiṣ*).³¹

Kāshifī accordingly relies on this work—the first summa of Islamic Pythagoreanism—at key points in his commentary on the Fātiḥa, and especially in his explanation as to why the letter *B*, symbol of duality, rather than *A*, symbol of unity, opens the Quran. After adumbrating the positions of Ibn 'Arabī, Ḥamūya and Qūnavī on this point, he summarizes their betic cosmogony:

By way of concluding the foregoing discussion we may cite the author of the *Investigations* (God gladden his grave): The letter *B* connotes the presence of inclusive oneness (*vāḥidiyyat*), the beginning of the chain of existents, as suggested by the saying “From *B* manifested being (*wa-mina l-bā' zahara l-wujūd*).” That the [divine] Speech opens with this letter, the mover of the chain of witnessing, is thus not inappropriate. The same author says: The letter *B* connotes the first entification (*ta'ayyun-i avval*), also called the Muḥam-madan Reality (*ḥaqīqat-i Muḥammadi*) (the profoundest blessings be upon him and his House). The correspondence of the letter *B* to this reality is clear, in that the union of opposites (*ta'ānuq-i aṭrāf*), one of the noble properties of the Seal—as the poet sings:

For me opposites embrace, the rug of otherness
rolled away: all things are equal!³²

²⁹ Ibid. 167.

³⁰ See Albertson, *Mathematical theologies*.

³¹ Melvin-Koushki, *The quest* ch. 7.

³² Ibn al-Fāriḍ, *al-Tā'iyya al-kubrā* l. 227. This thirteenth-century poetic masterpiece became a major Akbarian teaching text and object of commentary. Ibn Turka's prosimetric *Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-durar*, however, a brilliant Persian entry into the new anthology-as-commentary genre, is the first to retrieve its specifically literary gorgeousness to create a Persian-Arabic poetical canon—precisely the project of Kāshifī too here and elsewhere; see Melvin-

—is realized at the level of this letter. Its embodiment of Two is simultaneously the most proximal to One and the most distant therefrom; it comprehends both primacy and duality; it therefore unites opposites (*mu'taniq-i azdād*). This, as is clear to gnostics, is precisely a quality peculiar to the Seal. Whoso heeds the call [*I have time with God*] wherein no angel can share and the declaration *I am but human* (Q 18:110, 41:6) with the ear of understanding, whoso beholds the manifest beauty of *Bilal*, give us relief³³ and the coquetry of *Talk to me, little fair-skinned one*³⁴ with the eye of insight,

He knows what the path of all-comprehensiveness (*jāmi'īyyat*) is like.³⁵

More, according to the verse *A messenger from among yourselves* as qualified by [the divine names] *gentle, compassionate* (Q 9:128), a further part of that here discussed will become plain to intelligent minds. It is by virtue of this relation that one of the magnificent names applied to the holy [Prophetic] eminence (the blessings of the All-Merciful be upon him and his House) in the Quran is precisely the adjective “second”: *The second of the two when the two were in the cave* (Q 9:40). The primordial precedence of the reality of the Prophet is clear, and the correspondence of *B* therewith here firmly established—hence the appropriateness of opening the [divine] Speech with reference to the master of mankind (*sayyid-i anām*) (blessings and peace be upon him and his House) by way of this letter.

Certain knowers of secrets hold that *B* opens [the Quran] because of its comprehensiveness. In the *Great Sun of Gnostes* (*Shams al-ma'ārif-i kabīr*) [of Shaykh Būnī] it is stated, for example, that the letter *B* is an occult mystery that imparts its blessing to all things whenever it manifests. It is related more plainly in the [*Meccan*] *Openings* (*Futūḥāt*) that Shaykh Abū Madyan (his spirit be sanctified) once said: “I see nothing but that it has a *B* written upon it.”³⁶ All such statements speak at base of the all-comprehensive nature [of the *B*], showing the way via the secret *Through me does everything subsist and become manifest*³⁷ and making known the essence of the statement *He is with you wherever you are* (Q 57:4)—but this witness and oneness is beyond the compass of howness, and cannot be grasped through reason.³⁸

Koushki, The quest 380-415.

³³ I.e., by performing the *adhān* to initiate the prayer.

³⁴ *Humayrā'*, addressing 'Ā'isha.

³⁵ A similar passage occurs in Ibn Turka's Persian treatise *On the Dot* (*R. Nuqṭa*), and the same topic is treated in his Arabic treatise *On the B*. Both are edited and translated in Melvin-Koushki, *Persian Pythagoreanism*.

³⁶ Ibn 'Arabī, *al-Futūḥāt al-Makkiyya* i, 102.

³⁷ Ibid.

³⁸ *Javāhir al-tafsīr* 344-6.

The Grammar of Lettrist Tafsir

Despite its name, letter science is the science of language as such, read and written cosmically. This includes (Arabic) grammar. Here Kāshifī's two invocations of the famous grammarian and infamous magician Sirāj al-Dīn Sakkākī (d. 1229) are especially telling: though no lettrist, this Mongol-era metalworker turned scholar married grammar to grimoire so deftly as to prefigure and help inspire the post-Mongol boom of lettrism.³⁹

As a leading agent of the same, Kāshifī provides the reader with the grammatical terminology necessary to decipher any lettrist tafsir at various points in his introduction to the *Javāhir*, particularly in section six on the meaning of the letter and the dot and their modulations through vowellessness, lengthening and doubling. In the passage translated below, he artfully combines, per his usual canonizing procedure, Ibn Sīnā, Jurjānī, Ibn 'Arabī, an anonymous but popular sermon manual, Fakhr-i Rāzī, Ḥamūya and Qūnavī, spangled with his own catchy verses:

Know that *ḥarf* (letter) etymologically means the edge or end of something. In philosophical usage, it denotes a mode of utterance whereby one voiced sound can be distinguished from another despite their similarity through sharpness or heaviness as perceived by the hearer, so defined in the Ultimate Master [Ibn Sīnā's] treatise [*On Phonetics (R. fī Makhārij al-ḥurūf)*].⁴⁰ Some further call a letter any vocally uttered form perceptible to all. The holy eminence Sayyid [Sharīf Jurjānī] (his spirit be sanctified) in his *Commentary on The Stations (Sharḥ-i Mawāqif)* states: The quiddity (*māhiyya*) of the letter is more manifest than those things used to define it, just as the sensing of particulars is stronger and more direct than any explicating definition of the essences of sensibilia can be, given that the latter necessarily depends on additions and extrapolations, which allow no understanding of their reality as such.

[By contrast], a preeminent Realizer⁴¹ stated that the letter in reality is a form sent down from the heaven of holiness to manifest everything as it is, to explicate its end and its essence. This it does either in writing, whereby books and tablets are inscribed through the medium of fingers and hands, or in speech, whereby they take form through the medium of air as modified by lips and tongue.

The letter is a decanter poured into soul's cup
pouring out wine from the vat of secrets.

³⁹ Ibid. 566, 645. See Selove and Humble (eds.), *A sorcerer's handbook*, including my afterword to the volume, A grammar of weirding.

⁴⁰ Melvin-Koushki, World as (Arabic) text 397-8.

⁴¹ *Yakī az akābir-i ahl-i taḥqīq*: i.e., Ibn Turka, referred to anonymously as a sign of respect, whose treatise *On Letters* Kāshifī closely paraphrases twice in this passage. Likewise, *taḥqīq* is often synonymous with lettrism as Realism in New Brethren parlance. Thus while "Realizer" is technically correct, this descriptor has rather the valorizing charge of "scientist" and "empiricist philosopher" in Modern English—or even better, "cosmo-semiotician," à la Peirce; see Melvin-Koushki, *Taḥqīq* vs. *taqlīd*.

The holy eminence [and Supreme] Master (God sanctify us with his spirit) in the first book of the second chapter of his [*Meccan*] *Openings* notes that the letters constitute a nation like any other, and so receive divine revelation and are charged thereby through prophets from among them, and each has a name fitted to it—something known only to experiencers of true unveiling (*kashf*). Yet the realm of the letter is the vastest of all realms with respect to language and the clearest of them all in exposition.⁴² Thus one of this holy eminence's lines:

The letters are the leaders of all expression
to which the tongues of Qurankeepers testify.

All the letters in the Quran—the vessels and fundamentals of all meaning and reality—come to 321,000, with various additions, which in the Meccan and Medinan recitation come to 250, in the Basran to 200, in the Kufan to 180 and in the Syrian to 188. Regardless of this discrepancy through the difference in quranic recitations, an authentic hadith assures us that any reciter of the Quran will be credited the equivalent of ten good works on his work record for every letter recited. According to the Meccan and Medinan recitation, this means a credit of 3,212,500 good works for every complete recitation of the Quran—*And God provides whomever He will without reckoning* (Q 2:212, etc.). Of this number, *A* occurs most frequently, and *Z* the least, according to the reading of the imam ‘Abd al-‘Azīz b. ‘Abd Allāh al-Murabbī (?), among the most prominent of readings: *A* occurs 48,800 times, more than any other, and *Z* 642, less than any other. The leading authorities of this art have all written on each letter of the alphabet as it occurs in the Quran, though their accounts likewise differ. As that may be, it should be known that each letter is a vessel to the wine of realization, and each expression the portion of the masters of verification and divine blessing.

In *Subtleties of the Confirmation* (*Laṭā’if al-taqrīr*) it is stated that every [quranic] *A* is an allusion to intimacy (*ishārat-i ulfatī*), every *B* to tidings of nearness (*bishārat-i zulfatī*), every *T* to perfect joy (*tamām-i bahjatī*), every *Th* to incontrovertible proof (*ṣubūt-i ḥujjatī*), every *J* to attracting sufficiency (*jazb-i kifāyatī*), [and so on] ...⁴³ And how beautifully it has been sung:

Each of its letters is a blooming garden
blazing more brightly than a lamp at night,
As blissful as the sweetness of youth,
as lifegiving as the water of life,
More heartstopping than any houri's locks,

⁴² Cf. *Futūḥāt al-Makkiyya* i, 58. Here as elsewhere, Kāshifī's translation hews fairly closely to the original, with paraphrastic moments, stitching it together with similarly short passages or lines of verse from the same source or jumping to others.

⁴³ This translation from an anonymous work on sermonizing—Kāshifī's own speciality—proceeds through the rest of the alphabet in a similarly loose allusive fashion. See *Javāhir al-tafsīr* 197; Ḥājī Khalīfa, *Kashf al-ẓunūn* ii, 1552.

more revivifying than any fresh bunch of fruit.

As for the *nuqṭa* (dot), it is derived from *naqṭ*, meaning to point. Its plural is *nuqat* and *niqāṭ*, on the patterns of *ghurfā* and *ghuraf*, *nukṭa* and *nikāt*. *ʿAjṃ* (testing, needing clarification) is synonymous with *naqṭ* [in this sense], hence dotted letters are also called clarifying letters (*ḥurūf-i muʿjama*). To the extent that all [Arabic] letters are designated as clarifying, this refers to their written form, which through their abundance of dots distinguishes them from [the alphabets of] all other peoples. In *Keys to the Unseen* (*Mafātīḥ al-ghayb*) [of Fakhr-i Rāzī],⁴⁴ dotted letters are assigned to the physical (*mulkī*) realm, and undotted ones to the psychical (*malakūtī*). A total of 110,357 quranic letters are dotted, the rest undotted. Of the former, 63,697 have one dot, of which 40,473 have the dot above the letter, the rest below. Letters with two dots are 42,931, of which 70,012 have them above, the rest below. Letters with three dots, [all above], are 3,529. This makes 160,346 [quranic] dots in total⁴⁵—each of which comprises a lesson on Onemaking (*tawḥīd*): for the dot is the origin of all letters, without which they cannot be written. As the author of *The Beloved* (*al-Maḥbūb*), [Saʿd al-Dīn Ḥamūya] (God sanctify his mighty secret), incants:

A single dot became A and A all the letters—
hence the A in every lettername!⁴⁶

By the same token, the particularities of each letter can only be distinguished through recourse to the dot, which therefore constitutes both the letter's origin and its return. The intelligent and attentive will be put in mind of the principle *From Him it began and to Him it will return*, and the secret of *As We originated the first creation so shall We bring it back again* (Q 21:104) will be revealed to him.

The light of all beings dawns from it
and they all return to it,
As everything has its origin in it
they must find in it their end:
Old or new, all
must return by the way they came.

As for the letters' modulations, first are their short vowelings or movements (*ḥarakāt*), referred to as *iʿrāb* (clarification, inflection) by elite and commoner alike. But I refer not to the *iʿrāb* of the grammarians. For the term *iʿrāb* literally means to make manifest (*iḏhār*); I therefore use *ḥarakat* here in reference to its root and active meaning, whereby it signifies that which makes manifest the letter, whether in terms of its [physical] utterance or in

⁴⁴ Aka *Tafsīr-i kabīr*; see Noble, *Philosophising the occult*.

⁴⁵ This sum does not quite add up—perhaps an error in the edition?

⁴⁶ I.e., letternames like *mīm* or *nūn* when expanded reveal the A too, a procedure that can be indefinitely repeated: *MYM-YA-MYM* > *MYM-YA-MYM-YA-ALF-MYM-YA-MYM*, etc. On this key lettrist work see Uy, *Lost in a sea*.

terms of its spiritual formation. Thus does the author of the [Meccan] *Openings* (God provision us with his openings and transmit to his spirit our greetings) state that all realities arise from these movements, rendering them either active or passive, subject or object. Therefore do they manifest the reality of the meaning intended by their speaker. But they themselves can only manifest after the letters have been arranged, in that the *ḥarakāt* are simply minor letters, just as words are composed of letters [as their smaller parts]. The ordering of letters is thus like the shaping and constitutional balancing of [human] individuals, and the addition of these vowel movements to the letters like the investment of a shaped body with spirit: *When I have shaped him and breathed into him My spirit* (Q 15:29, 38:72). Likewise, a body's receptivity and aptitude depend on its form, and so too does vowel movement depend on the letters' receptivity and arrangement.

The Quran comprises 137,633 such movements, both declined and indeclinable. Each movement or nonmovement (*sukūn*, rest, vowellessness) of the quranic letters contains secrets known only to specialists. In *Subtleties of the Confirmation* it is stated that lovers [of God] derive from each *sukūn* peace of mind and from each *ḥarakat* comprehensive blessing (*barakat*), from each *a* vowel (*fatha*) the opening (*fath*) of the gates of safety, from each *i* vowel (*kasra*) the breaking (*kasr*) of the foundations of betrayal, from each accusative (*naṣb*) the erecting (*naṣb*) of the standards of state, from each genitive (*jarr*) the drawing (*jarr*) of the robe-hems of glory, from each nominative (*rafʿ*) the raising (*rafʿ*) of the degree of reverence, from each *u* vowel (*ḍamma*) the joining (*ḍamm*) of blessing to blessing.

Its *a* opens religion's treasures,
its accusative erects the banners of certainty,
In its *u* is flourishing,
from its nominative the exaltation of knowledge,
And if notice be drawn to its genitive
it spells safety from all breakage till the Day of Doom.

Know that the conjunction of the dot with the *ḥarakāt* comprise many further secrets of universal import. Like the dots, the short vowels are either above or below the line, and both together are limited to four possible configurations in a given word: both above; both below; the dotting above and the vowelizing below; the vowelizing above and the dotting below. Specialists in realization have much to say about each of these four configurations with respect to activity and passivity, imbalance and balance, spiritual powers and natural ones and the overcoming of each by the other, most of which discussions may be found in *The Inimitable Exposition in Explication of the Quranic Matrix* (*Iʿjāz al-bayān fī tafsīr umm al-Qurʾān*) [of Ṣadr al-Dīn Qūnavī].

Whoever likes to pick flowers
has got to see that garden!⁴⁷

⁴⁷ *Javāhir al-tafsīr* 214-20. The section concludes with a discussion of vowellessness, vowel lengthening (*madd*) and vowel doubling (*tashdīd*). Cf. Ibn Turka's short treatise *On the Meaning of the Properties of Morphology* (*R. dar*

From Akbarian-Ḥamūyan Theory to Būnian Practice

That garden, of course, is the *Javāhir* itself: no mere anthology (*gulistān*), it provides a general template for living lettrism in Akbarian-Ḥamūyan theory and Būnian practice. A few examples must here suffice.

A significant percentage of the first volume of the *Javāhir* is devoted to discussions of the three divine names in the *basmala*, in both theoretical and practical terms. Among the former is the following passage, from Kāshifī's fourth point in explication of the Supreme Name, synthesizing Qūnavī, Bābā Ruknā, Rūzbihān Baqlī, Jāmī, Sa'dī, Fanārī, Ibn 'Arabī and 'Aṭṭār:

In the *Inimitable Exposition* it is stated that God (*Allāh*) is the all-comprehensive name (*ism-i jāmi'-i kullī*) in that it is nonspecific in philosophical terms, and to link anything to it is invalid. Thus every act of attention to or invocation or supplication of that name can only be relative and based on a partial, delimited association, according to the state of the one attentive, invoking or supplicating, as with, for example, one sick or drowning: their supplication of this name is in relation to healing or salvation, and so on according to the same principle.

In his commentary on the *Ringstones of Wisdom* (*Sharḥ-i Fuṣūs al-ḥikam*), Shaykh Rukn al-Dīn Shīrāzī (God have mercy on him) states that *Allāh* is the name of the divine essence in itself from the perspective of exclusive oneness (*aḥadiyyat*), but from the perspective of inclusive oneness (*vāḥidiyyat*) it is the name of the attributes, in that it comprises all of the divine names and attributes, and is therefore all-comprehensive.

In the *Brides [of Exposition]* ('*Arā'is [al-bayān]*') [of Rūzbihān Baqlī] it is stated that *Al-lāh* is the name of comprehensiveness (*jam'*), given that each divine name partakes of one of its divine attributes specifically, but it itself, associated with the divine essence as well as all its attributes, must necessarily realize the attribute of comprehensiveness. However, the secrets of the comprehensive name cannot be revealed except to those adept in unification (*jam'īyyat*), which is to say the concentration of focus (*ijtimā'-i himmat*) on the Real alone, returning from the Many to the One.

In retreat we ignore all creation,
we flee all to sit with you.⁴⁸

On the same theme it has likewise been sung:

Since the heart is divided by all,
let it cleave to the One and reject the all!⁴⁹

Ma'nī-yi khavāṣṣ-i 'ilm-i ṣarf), edited and translated in Melvin-Koushki, *Persian Pythagoreanism*.

⁴⁸ Sa'dī, ghazal 434: *mā dar khalvat bi rū-yi khalq bi-bastīm*.

⁴⁹ Jāmī, quatrain: *ay dar dīl-i tū hizār mushkil zi hama*.

In Fanārī's *Exegesis [of the Opening]*⁵⁰ it is likewise stated that *Allāh* is called the all-comprehensive name in its comprehending all attributes of perfection (*kamāl*). Similarly, the author of the [*Meccan*] *Openings* (God sanctify his spirit) states that the meaning of divinity (*ulūhiyyat*) consists in its freedom from need for any other but the need of all others for it. The first part has to do with majesty (*jalāl*), the second with beauty (*jamāl*). Perfection is the comprising of both attributes, as does the name God. Its all-comprehensiveness is therefore such that, despite its constant invocation in every tongue and its ubiquitous engravement on the tablet of every heart, no one knows it, and it is alien to every soul.

O you who inhabit my soul—and my soul all senseless of you!
 The world is full of you—and the world all senseless of you!
 You're engraven on my heart—and my heart wholly ignorant of you!
 You're on my lips—and my lips all senseless of you!⁵¹

Like the Quran itself, the divine names it comprises are thus cosmic in structure. In his fifth point on the realities of the Supreme Name, composed of five letters, Kāshifī significantly cites the New Brother Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī's bestselling Persian manual on the riddle genre (*mu'ammā*), which proposes the cosmos as a whole to be a mathematical riddle whose primary key is the science of lettrism:

The *Embroidered Robes* (*Hulal-i muṭarraz*) (God refresh the spirit of its author) states: If anyone but looks with the eye of reflection, he will always perceive the universal categories (*kullīyyāt*) to be five at base. The first example is contingent substances (*javāhir-i mumkina*), which specialist scholars have posited as the basis of all existents and likewise determined to be five: mind (*'aql*), soul (*nafs*), prime matter (*hayūlā*), form (*ṣūra*) and body (*jism*).⁵²

So much for theory; what of practice? In his eighth point in explication of the name pair All-Merciful Ever-Merciful (*al-Raḥmān al-Raḥīm*), Kāshifī combines Ibn 'Abbās, Yāfī', Būnī, Pārsā and Tamīmī, giving Būnī pride of place, to offer this clinching account of experimentalist lettrist technology:

Before putting into writing two or three matters as to the active properties of letters and words, [it should be stated that] the wise and just reader, having stripped from the face of his thought the veil of partisanship and recalcitrance and closely investigated the encompassing nature of the quranic effluxions, will without doubt find hyperbole and expatiation unnecessary. And even the unjust and recalcitrant reader, should he chance to reflect on

⁵⁰ Fanārī, *Tafsīr al-Fātiḥa*, aka *'Ayn al-a'yān*—that this is not a lettrist work is confirmed by Kāshifī's citation pattern of the same.

⁵¹ *Javāhir al-tafsīr* 363-64. The lines are by 'Aṭṭār, ghazal 394: *ay dar darūn-i jānam u jān az tū bī-khabar*.

⁵² *Javāhir al-tafsīr* 367. On the *Hulal-i muṭarraz* see Melvin-Koushki, The quest 379-89; Binbaş, *Intellectual networks* 48, 81-9; on lettrism as "riddle consciousness" see Melvin-Koushki, Of Islamic grammatology.

the verse *We send down of the Quran that which is a healing and a mercy* (Q 17:82), must admit that its most obvious sense asserts that the Holy Quran has two universal benefits that accrue to firm believers, each of whose realization is inextricable from the other's. The first is bodily healing, as denoted by the word 'healing' (*shifā'*); the second is spiritual healing, as denoted by the word 'mercy' (*rahma*). The first accordingly was bestowed to remove physical ills, the second to preserve spiritual health: the quranic effluxion both restores physical imbalances to their natural balance and protects one's spirit to against accessions of weakness and incapacity on the path toward divine knowledge. The Quran is thus a medicine simultaneously occult and manifest, healing physical and spiritual ailments in equal measure. Likewise the sense of the Prophet's blessed saying *The Quran was revealed in seven letters, all of which are healing and sufficiency*, an authentic hadith, which indicates its letters and words comprise the same. And just as their healing is of universal application, so too their sufficiency: any thisworldly or otherworldly need may through the blessings of the Quran be sufficed.

Make your request of the Quran as you will—
through it all bothworldly aims are achieved!

Now the mode of employing the furqanic words for such ends is either through recitation or writing. As for recitation, it may be performed according to specific numerical constraint or freely, any number of times. Likewise with writing: either by writing out the letters or by converting them into a magic square (*wafq*).⁵³ Here I will discuss the former method only. It is more efficacious to have them written by an imam. This procedure completed, one then benefits by bearing them on one's person, however that may be, whether in pendant form as with an amulet, or worn as with a ring, or dissolved in water, rosewater or similar liquids and drunk or wiped over a body part. Layth son of Mujāhid (God have mercy on them both) transmitted, [for example], that giving such a quranic tincture to the ill to drink was a permitted practice, a transmission that occurs in Qurṭubī's *Exegesis*. Similar prescriptions have been transmitted from the Imams of the House of the Prophet. God knows best!

Because I have repeatedly promised to discuss [in this exegesis] certain of the active properties and applications of quranic verses and words, then, I shall undertake to very briefly do so here on those of the words of the *basmala*—God benefit us and all Muslims therewith!

In the book *Gift to God's Servants* (*Hibat al-'ibād*) of Anas b. Mālīk it is transmitted that the holy Messenger (God bless and keep him and House) said that anyone who recites *In the name of God, All-Merciful, Ever-Merciful; there is no power nor strength save in God, Exalted, Supreme* twice daily will be cleansed from his sins, and God Most High will protect him against 70 kinds of afflictions, including leprosy, elephantiasis and hemiplegia. In *Soul's Gardens* (*Riyāz al-janān*) of Ibn 'Abbās (God be pleased with him and his father) this

⁵³ On which core lettrist technology see Hallum, *New light*.

statement is confirmed, that those who recite this phrase thereby deflect 70 afflictions, the most minor being sorrow and lassitude.

Says Imam Abū ‘Abd Allāh al-Yāfi‘ī in his *Strung Pearl* (*Durr al-naẓīm*): Whoever frequently recites *In the name of God, All-Merciful, Ever-Merciful* will achieve prominence and the respect of elites and commoners alike. He likewise prescribes its recitation 12,000 times to fulfill any need or achieve any objective, with the proviso that two prayer cycles be performed after every thousand recitations and mention of the need, continuing that procedure until all 12,000 recitations are completed—and one’s need or objective will surely be realized.

Shaykh Abū l-‘Abbās [Būnī] (God have mercy on him) in his *Great Sun of Gnoscs* similarly prescribes: Writing *In the name of God, All-Merciful, Ever-Merciful* 640 times and carrying the product everywhere will make you empowered, honored and respected, and incline everyone to love you. He also mentions other effects of these three divine names separately.

The holy eminence Lord Pārsā (God sanctify his spirit) in his *Commentary on the Names of God* (*Sharḥ-i asmā’-i Allāh*) states: Whoever recites *O God* a thousand times daily will achieve certainty; whoever recites *O All-Merciful* a hundred times after each prayer will have all heedlessness, forgetfulness and stiffness driven from his heart; and whoever recites *O Ever-Merciful* a hundred times [after each prayer] will become a friend and benefactor [to all].

It is transmitted from Ibrāhīm Tamīmī (God have mercy on him) [in his *Active Properties*] that the holy eminence Elijah (peace be upon him and our Prophet) taught how to fulfill one’s desires as follows: Whoever has a desire he cannot achieve should after performing the afternoon prayer on Friday refrain from any litany, but rather with perfect concentration repeatedly invoke these two names of the Real—*God* and *All-Merciful*—until sunset, at which moment he should prostrate and state his need.

In Būnī’s *Enactments* (*Taṣāwīf*)⁵⁴ it is mentioned that the name *Ever-Merciful* has a wondrous special property (*khāṣṣiyat-i ‘ajīb*) effective in securing one from worldly tribulations generally and the wrath of kings and the opposition of enemy leaders specifically. [I speak from experience]: I once met a Maghribi fellow in town who was in great fear [for his life] because of the ruling sultan, and advised him to repeat *O Ever-Merciful!* He did so continuously [in retreat] for seven days, and on the eighth emerged, whereupon the sultan’s servants [arrested him and] brought him to the royal presence. But when the sultan turned his attention to him, he instead spoke to him with graciousness and affection and gifted him money and a robe, and he went out from his presence under divine protection and in perfect health and safety.

In certain of [Būnī’s] treatises are discussions of three hundred special properties of the *basmala* that are similarly tried and true (*mujarrab*), but space does not permit them to be enumerated in the likes of this account, so these must suffice—and *God sees His servants* (Q 3:15, etc.).⁵⁵

⁵⁴ Cf. Gardiner, *Esotericism* 26, 38.

⁵⁵ *Javāhir al-tafsīr* 407-10.

While inherently universal, this technology is thus particularly useful for medical, political and financial ends. (Ibn Turka, ‘Alī Ṣafī and Taṣköprizāde all emphasize the same in their own lettrist works.⁵⁶) Kāshifī therefore concludes the first volume of the *Javāhir* with ten operations drawn from Būnī, Yāfī‘ī, Tamīmī and Imam ‘Alī for activating the *khavāṣṣ* of the Fātiḥa, with emphasis on similar applications:

Scholars specializing in the active properties of the Quran have identified one thousand such properties of this sura, some establishing them [through personal experience]. Given that this is the greatest and most excellent of all quranic suras, and the Quran as a whole is the ultimate source and mine of benefit and utility, it is no wonder that so many special properties of this sura have been adduced.

[Chief among such scholars is] the godly imam Abū ‘Abd Allāh Būnī, who in his *Fragrant Ode on the Active Properties of The Opening (Fā’iḥa fī khavāṣṣ al-Fātiḥa)*⁵⁷ treats of various objectives in this regard, and declares that should you wish to attain all these and more from

The Opening of the Book—when you contemplate therein
a secret, which of its countless secrets might that be?

Here I will merely mention ten such properties proven by experimentation (*tajriba*):

1. Healing all pains: Hence its being dubbed “the sura of healing.”
2. Antidote to poisons: In the *Comely Excellences (Faḏāyil-i malīḥī)* [the Companion] Abū Sa‘īd Khudrī (God be pleased with him) reports that the holy Prophet (God bless and keep him and his House) stated: *The Opening of the Book is an antidote to every poison* (so it is cited in the *Garden of Reports (Firdaws al-akhbār)* [of Shīrawayh Daylamī]). It is likewise called the sura of the spell (*ruqyā*), which involves blowing (*nafṣ*) [on the body of the afflicted while reciting], specifically its middle verse *You only do we serve, You only do we pray for succor!*
3. Safety and health while traveling: It is reported in *Soul’s Gardens (Riyāz al-janān)* from the Commander of the Faithful ‘Alī (peace be upon him) that if you wish to undertake any travel and arrive safely and securely, recite the Opening thrice, then pray: “O God, preserve me and that with me! Keep me and that with me! Let me and that with me reach my destination!” In some versions of this report the Throne Verse and the sura Sincere Religion are to be included as well.

⁵⁶ See, respectively, Melvin-Koushki, *The New Brethren*; idem, *Qizilbash magic*; idem, *Taṣköprizāde*.

⁵⁷ Presumably the possibly authentic work attested in the fifteenth century as *al-Abyāt fī faḏā’il al-Fātiḥa wa-barakati-hā*; Gardiner, *Esotericism* 383.

4. Relieving fever: [In his *Strung Pearl*], Imam Yāfi'i cites a report of Imam Ja'far Ṣādiq (peace be upon him) to the effect that one should recite this sura forty times over a cup of water, then sprinkle some on the patient's face, whereupon his fever will break.
5. Improving memory: In Tamīmī's *Active Properties* it is related that writing it with pure musk on a glass cup, washing it with rosewater, then imbibing at dawn, while fasting, for seven consecutive days will strengthen one's memory to such an extent that one will remember everything one hears.
6. Protection from treachery, envy, arrogance and such threats: Persist in reciting it daily 248 times.
7. Relieving ear pain: Write it with rose oil, wipe it and put a drop in the ear.
8. Curing gout, hemiplegia, sciatica, etc.: Write it on a clean vessel and douse with balsam oil, then recite it over the oil 70 times, and apply as needed to the affected area.
9. Curing ulcers and spotting: Recite it with this intention 40 times between the supererogatory and required dawn prayer.
10. Prosperity: Reciting it 100 times after each required prayer will give one ample income, without need to rely on others, God Most High willing.

Because fully enumerating the active properties of the Opening is impossible, and the objective in this translation is brevity, I have limited myself to this selection. God only guides and empowers in the performance of what is right!⁵⁸

Quranic Inimitability as Magic

Following Kāshifī's injunction, this article has provided only a brief taste of the canonizing, combinatory texture of the exceptional lettrist tafsir that is his *Jewels of Exegesis* as spur for further research. Despite its exceptionality, however, the *Javāhir* is no mere esoteric one-off, but rather a masterful and influential synthesis of mainstream Persianate philosophical, religious, political, scientific and technological culture at the turn of the sixteenth century, during the post-Mongol heyday of Islamic empire. The same culture remained vital and productive across the Afro-Eurasian ecumene to and through the colonial period. Lettrism was often at the heart of both Islamic reformism and anticolonial resistance too, as new research has shown, and is alive and well today, though a staggering amount of philological and anthropological work remains to be done on all these fronts.⁵⁹

⁵⁸ *Javāhir al-tafsīr* 861-4.

⁵⁹ See e.g. Morgan, Spokesman; Melvin-Koushki and Pickett, Mobilizing magic; Doostdar, *Iranian metaphysicals*.

The *Javāhir al-tafsīr* itself is a quintessentially late Timurid and Herati imperial product, written on the eve of the Safavid takeover of Iran—after which the brand of Sunni-Shi‘i lettrism it codifies continued to boom. In it Kāshifī ecumenically and encyclopedically marries occult theory to occult practice to remake tafsir as both a religious science and a reformist, real-world technology.⁶⁰ Crucially, he marries such disparate authorities as Jurjānī and Būnī to redefine the science’s originary doctrine of quranic inimitability (*i‘jāz*) as a form of *experimentalist magic*.⁶¹

The historiographical implications of this exquisite, bejeweled Timurid marriage of opposites across multiple genres and disciplines are sweeping indeed. Most notably, that ‘Alī Ṣafī insists on his father’s *Javāhir* and *Mavāhib* as twinned lettrist manifestos—the latter being among the most successful tafsirs of all time—suggests that Islamicists more generally should hesitate to divorce exoteric from esoteric, Arabic from Persian and “classical” from early modern, as is still too often the rule. As Kāshifī, “Unveiler of the Occult,” summarizes in this passage on the Supreme Name, citing Ibn ‘Arabī and versifying the quranic motto of the New Brethren:

In the [*Meccan*] *Openings* it is stated that the two *Ls* [of the name *Allāh* (*ALLH*)] indicate the manifest and occult aspect of that name respectively, positioned as they are between its opening and closing *As*.⁶² Thus do they serve to join the twain, thus does end turn back on beginning and so complete the circle.

Here the beginning *is* the end,
the occult *is* the manifest!⁶³

It is this Islamicate marriage of Yin and Yang, this Persianate completion of the hermeneutic and the technic circles in tandem, Kāshifī argues, that works in the world all the weirdness and wonders of the Quran. For in the immeasurable kabbalistic structure that is the cosmos, we are not only the written—we are also the writers.

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⁶⁰ The Safavid New Brother Maḥmūd Dihdār Shīrāzī (fl. 1576), the most prolific Persian author on lettrism of the next century, pursued the same project; see Melvin-Koushki, Occult ecumenism.

⁶¹ On a similar theme see Selove, Poetry as magic.

⁶² I.e., according to its leeternames: *ALF-LAM-LAM-HA*.

⁶³ *Javāhir al-tafsīr* 373; this line translates the opening epigram. For a broader treatment of this theme see Murata, *The Tao of Islam*.

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